

Louis Andrada

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Artist Statement

I am a Brazilian-born, Toronto-based artist.

Growing up, I struggled to express myself the way others seemed to. It left me feeling isolated, carrying emotions I could not understand.

Since childhood, I have been drawn to horror movies, folklore, and fear. These were spaces where I found comfort when I could not find it within myself.

It was only much later that I discovered painting as the place where my emotions could take shape. What goes onto the canvas is everything that I wished could have been said and never was.

My practice originates in the merging of my fascination with occult symbolism and the expression of my own unexplored emotions. Each work is less an invention than an extraction, taking what already exists internally and forcing it into visibility.

My technical foundation is in analog film photography and darkroom production. That training established how I think about images: through grain, tonal contrast, chemical disruption, forms that develop slowly and resist full resolution. I do not produce commercial photographs anymore, but those processes continue to live inside how I paint. Surfaces are built through sequential pigment layering that simulates exposure, degradation, and controlled deterioration. Figures emerge gradually, caught between visibility and collapse.

Painting functions as containment for me. Internal images tied to fear, unease, and grief would otherwise remain formless and intrusive. The canvas fixes them into a physical state and holds them there. In the battle of giving form to what I fear most, my images erode and resist full resolution; they do not want to be fully seen.

If not asked, I personally tend to avoid speaking publicly about the meaning behind each of my works. I believe that when artists do, their interpretation can become the only accepted one, and the viewer's own reading quietly disappears. I would rather the work remain open.

The titles are where I tend to deposit my own feelings. They are the one place I allow my response to exist without erasing anyone else's. They are also a record against time. Someday I will not be here to speak for these pieces, and the titles ensure my feelings do not disappear with me.

Some works carry no title at all. Those are the ones even I cannot find words for.

If our paths cross and you wish to understand what lies behind a particular work, I am willing to share the thoughts and emotions that shaped it. However, I hope my interpretation remains only one possible entry point. A work should continue to exist beyond the artist, allowing each viewer to encounter it through their own memories, fears, and experiences.